

STANDARD VISITOR VISA FOR UK

Overview

If you need a Standard Visitor visa, you must apply online before you travel to the UK and attend an appointment at a visa application centre.

The earliest you can apply is 3 months before you travel.

You must meet the eligibility requirements and only do permitted activities.

Check you meet the eligibility requirements

You must have a passport or travel document to enter the UK. It should be valid for the whole of your stay.

You must be able to show that:

- you'll leave the UK at the end of your visit
- you're able to support yourself and your dependants during your trip (or have funding from someone else to support you)
- you're able to pay for your return or onward journey (or have funding from someone else to pay for the journey)
- you'll not live in the UK for extended periods through frequent or successive visits, or make the UK your main home

You may need to meet extra eligibility requirements if you're visiting the UK:

- to study, do a placement or take an exam
- as an academic, senior doctor or dentist
- for a permitted paid engagement
- for medical reasons

What you can and cannot do ('permitted activities')

You can visit the UK as a Standard Visitor:

- for tourism, for example on a holiday or vacation
- to see your family or friends
- to volunteer for up to 30 days with a registered charity
- to pass through the UK to another country ('in transit')
- for certain business activities, for example attending a meeting or interview
- for certain paid engagements or events (a 'permitted paid engagement') as an expert in your profession, for example to give lectures or perform
- to take part in a school exchange programme
- to do a recreational course of up to 30 days, for example a dance course
- to study, do a placement or take an exam
- as an academic, senior doctor or dentist
- for medical reasons

You cannot:

- do paid or unpaid work for a UK company or as a self-employed person, unless you're doing a permitted paid engagement or event
- claim public funds (benefits)
- live in the UK for long periods of time through frequent or successive visits
- marry or register a civil partnership, or give notice of marriage or civil partnership - you'll need to apply for a Marriage Visitor visa

Visa fees

You can apply for a Standard Visitor visa, or if you visit the UK regularly you can choose to apply for a long-term Standard Visitor visa instead.

	Fee	Maximum length of stay
Standard Visitor visa	£127	6 months
Standard Visitor visa for medical reasons	£220	11 months
Standard Visitor visa for academics	£220	12 months
2 year long-term Standard Visitor visa	£475	6 months per visit
5 year long-term Standard Visitor visa	£848	6 months per visit
10 year long-term Standard Visitor visa	£1,059	6 months per visit

Apply online

Once you've started your application you can save your form and complete it later.

If you're applying with family members, each person must have their own application and pay the fee. They need to attend their own appointment at a visa application centre.

You can apply on behalf of your partner and child, if they cannot apply for themselves.

Long-term Standard Visitor visas

You can choose to apply for a long-term Standard Visitor visa if you visit the UK regularly. This visa lasts 2, 5 or 10 years. You can stay for a maximum of 6 months on each visit.

If you're under 18 years old when you apply, your long-term Standard Visitor visa will only be valid for up to 6 months after you turn 18. You cannot get a refund on the fee.

You may be given a shorter visa than requested if UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI) believe you cannot meet the eligibility requirements for the duration of the visa you applied for.

You will not get a refund of the application fee if you get a shorter visa or if your application is refused.

Your visa may be cancelled if your travel history shows you are repeatedly living in the UK for extended periods.

Documents and information you'll need to apply

You must have a passport or travel document that is valid for the whole of your stay in the UK.

You'll need to provide the following information in your online application:

- the dates you're planning to travel to the UK
- where you'll be staying during your visit
- how much you think your trip will cost
- your current home address and how long you've lived there
- your parents' names and dates of birth (if known)
- how much you earn in a year (if you have an income)

- details of any criminal, civil or immigration offences you may have committed

Depending on your circumstances, you might also need to provide:

- details of your travel history for the past 10 years
- your employer's address and telephone number
- your partner's name, date of birth and passport number
- the name and address of anyone paying for your trip
- the name, address and passport number of any family members you have in the UK
- a certificate proving that you've had a tuberculosis (TB) test if you're visiting for more than 6 months

You need to provide additional documents if you're visiting the UK:

- to study
- as an academic
- for certain paid engagements or events (a 'permitted paid engagement')
- for medical reasons

Proving your identity and providing your documents

As part of your online application, you need to book an appointment at a visa application centre. Allow time to attend your appointment, as the visa application centre could be in another country.

At your appointment, you'll need to:

- prove your identity with your passport or travel document
- have your fingerprints and a photo (biometric information) taken
- provide the required documents that show you're eligible for a Standard Visitor visa

You'll get your passport or travel document back on the same day. The visa application centre may keep some of your other documents while processing your application. You'll be told what they'll need when you apply.

How long it takes to get a decision

Once you've applied online, proved your identity and provided your documents, you'll usually get a decision on your visa within 3 weeks.

You can check to see if you can get your visa decision faster.

You'll get an email when the Home Office has made a decision on your application. This will explain what you need to do next.

When you can extend your stay

You may be able to extend your stay if you have permission to be in the UK for less than 6 months. You can extend your stay up to a total of 6 months.

You can only apply to stay in the UK for longer than 6 months if you're:

- a patient receiving medical treatment
- an academic and you still meet the eligibility requirements
- a graduate retaking the Professional and Linguistic Assessment Board (PLAB) test or doing a clinical attachment

You must apply to extend your stay and pay the £1,100 fee regardless of your nationality.

You need to apply while you're still in the UK and before your current visa or permission expires.

Fees to extend visa

It costs:

- £1,100 to extend your stay as a Standard Visitor
- an extra £1,000 if you use the super priority service

You'll also need to have your fingerprints and a photo (biometric information) taken - there's no fee for this.

If you have permission to be in the UK for less than 6 months

You may be able to extend your stay as long as the total time you spend in the UK is no more than 6 months. You must meet the eligibility requirements and pay the £1,100 fee.

For example, if you have been in the UK for 3 months, you can apply to extend your stay for 3 more months. This applies if you needed a visa to visit the UK and also if you did not need one.

If you need to stay longer for medical treatment

If you're already in the UK, you can apply to stay for a further 6 months if you:

- have paid for any treatment you've already had in the UK
- can and will pay the further costs of your treatment
- continue to meet the medical treatment eligibility requirements

There is no limit on how many times you can extend your stay. It costs £1,100 each time you extend.

Documents you must provide for extending visa

You must get a medical practitioner or NHS consultant who's registered in the UK to provide details of your medical condition that needs further treatment.

If you're having treatment at an NHS hospital under a reciprocal healthcare arrangement, you will need to provide another authorisation form from your country's government saying they will pay for your treatment.

If you need to stay longer as an academic

If you're already in the UK and have permission to visit for less than 12 months, you can apply to stay for up to 12 months in total.

Your partner and children can apply to stay for up to 12 months too. They must have their own application and each pay the £1,100 fee.

You must prove you:

- are highly qualified in your field of expertise, for example you have a PhD or higher
- were working in that field of expertise at an academic institution overseas prior to your arrival in the UK
- are not filling a permanent teaching post

If you're an academic, but not a senior doctor or dentist, you must also prove you're visiting to do research or a formal exchange.

If you're a senior doctor or dentist, you must also prove you're visiting to do research, clinical practice, a formal exchange or to teach.

Before you extend your stay, check if you need an Academic Technology Approval Scheme (ATAS) certificate. You may need one if you're researching certain subjects at postgraduate level or above.

If you need to stay longer to retake the PLAB test

If you're already in the UK, you can apply to extend your stay for up to 6 months to retake the PLAB test.

You must provide written confirmation from the General Medical Council that you're retaking the test.

If you want to do a clinical attachment or dental observer post

If you pass the PLAB test, you can apply to stay longer to do an unpaid clinical attachment or dental observer post.

You can stay in the UK for up to 18 months in total.

You must provide written confirmation:

- of your clinical attachment offer
- that you've not done a clinical attachment in the UK before

You must not treat patients.

Proving your identity and providing your documents

When you apply, you'll be asked to make an appointment at a UK Visa and Citizenship Application Services (UKVCAS) service point to provide your fingerprints and a photo (biometric information).

You'll also need to submit the supporting documents that prove your eligibility. You can:

- upload your documents into the online service

- have them scanned at your UKVCAS appointment

You must not travel outside of the UK, Ireland, the Channel Islands or the Isle of Man until you get a decision. Your application will be withdrawn if you do.

Apply to extend your stay as a Standard Visitor

Once you've started your application you can save your form and complete it later.

How long it takes to get a decision

If you use the standard service, a decision will usually be made within 8 weeks of providing your supporting documents and proving your identity.

If you use the super priority service a decision will be made:

- by the end of the next working day after your UKVCAS appointment if your appointment is on a weekday
- 2 working days after your UKVCAS appointment if your appointment is at the weekend

Working days are Monday to Friday, not including bank holidays.

You'll be contacted if your application is complex and will take longer, for example:

- if your supporting documents need to be verified
- if you need to attend an interview
- because of your personal circumstances (for example if you have a criminal conviction)

Once you've applied you can stay in the UK until you've been given a decision, as long as you applied before your permission to be in the UK ended.

If your application is successful

You'll get an eVisa (a digital record of your identity and immigration status).

Your decision email or letter will tell you how to get access to your eVisa. You'll need to create a UKVI account.